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by the time he left office in 2014, we did not hear much of a song and dance about it. Singh's policies were, therefore, supple and flexible; he could blend supply-side economics with measures to bolster demand and improve the living conditions of the lowest strata of society.

Never was this more apparent than in the 2008-09 "great recession", when he was also holding charge as Finance Minister. This catastrophe, triggered by the US subprime loan crisis, had brought

the developed world to its knees. India, which was growing increasingly integrated into the global economy, could not escape the reverberations. He responded with a set of measures that would both foster demand and support the supply side. There was across-the-board central excise duty reduction by 4 percentage points; additional Plan spending of ₹20,000 crore; additional borrowing by state governments of ₹30,000 crore for Plan expenditure; assistance to specific export

industries in the form of interest subsidy on export finance, refund of excise duties/central sales tax, and other export incentives; and a 2% reduction in central service tax. The total fiscal burden of these packages amounted to 1.8% of GDP.

Besides, measures were taken to support industries in trouble, such as the automobile industry, through such measures as opening a new window for the purchase of buses by state entities under the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission and fast forwarding purchase of vehicles by the Ministry of Defence. The RBI supported these measures with a range of policy measures. The cash reserve ratio (CRR) was brought down from 9% to 5%, the statutory liquidity ratio (SLR) from 25% to 24%, the repo rate from 9% to 4.75% and the reverse repo rate from 6% to 3.25%.

The Singh government was also credited with a number of significant welfare measures. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, the right to food security and the right to information all took birth in this period. Aadhaar was another important development. He roped in Nandan Nilekani to develop a perfect identification system, which now forms the basis of the technological progress achieved in the delivery of services, banking, direct benefit transfer and many other areas.

Singh was a complete economist. His work in multiple areas in the past, his strong academic credentials, his openness to ideas, his holistic understanding of the economy, his concern for all sections of society, particularly the poor, and his ability to build consensus made him a leader who India will never forget. **BT**

The writer is also the author of As Good as My Word. Views are personal